

BRIJ BHUSHAN SHARAN SINGH

WHY HE WAS FEARED AND LOATHED

- Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, 66, is a six-time Lok Sabha MP from Gonda, Balrampur and Kaiserganj in UP
- A student leader circa 1985, Singh cut his political teeth in the Ram temple movement. Was an accused in the Babri Masjid demolition. Acquitted in 2020
- Close to the late firebrand VHP leader Ashok Singhal, he joined the BJP in 1991. Won his first LS election from Gonda the same year
- Fielded wife Ketki Devi Singh from Gonda LS seat in 1996 as he couldn't get the ticket. She won. (There was a TADA case against him for allegedly harbouring associates of don Dawood Ibrahim. Got a clean chit later)
- Switched to the Samajwadi Party (SP) in 2009, won Kaiserganj LS seat
- Became president of the Wrestling Federation of India in 2011, reportedly with the help of then SP chief, the late Mulayam Singh Yadav
- A Thakur by caste, he owns 54 educational institutes that dot a 100-km stretch of the Ayodhya-Gonda highway. Some 80,000-odd students study in them
- In Nawabganj, 45 km from Gonda, he also owns a hotel, shooting range and wrestling academy
- Wife Ketki Devi is currently president of Gonda zila panchayat while son Prateek Bhushan Singh is MLA from Gonda Sadar
- Owns a fleet of SUVs, and also a Robinson R-66 turbine helicopter. Though his 2019 LS poll affidavit says Singh has movable and immovable assets worth just over Rs 4 crore, his wife lists assets worth Rs 6.3 crore
- At one point, Singh had over 40 criminal cases against him. Only four of them are pending per the affidavit. These include serious charges like attempt to murder and robbery
- Has also admitted to murder in a video interview last year. Another viral video from Dec. 2021 shows him slapping a young wrestler at an Under-15 national championship
- As WFI chief, he stands accused of many repeat acts of sexual harassment. The Delhi Police are probing seven such complaints. These include 14 specific incidents, five that took place just last year, in which he is alleged to have molested female wrestlers or sought sexual favours, threatening them with dire consequences if they didn't oblige

Rumours that Singh might stand for another WFI post and that his son Karan, already the V-P, might succeed him, horrified many

When they started their protest on January 18 at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi, the girls were bristling with resolve. They arrived at the site on a momentum that had gradually built up over the latter part of 2022. Dhriti Kumar (*name changed*), a female wrestler at the protest, recounts what happened at the time, as she levels serious charges against Singh. "Bhushan is a well-known terror for all women at WFI. He is so powerful that everyone has always been too afraid to speak out. If you do, then your career is over," she says, explaining the sense of despair they felt. "Wrestlers can't get another 'job'—there is just one organisation and he controls it. But we knew his term was to end in 2023 and so we thought it will all end soon."

Then, rumours began circulating that Singh was planning to contest another post at the WFI and that his son, Karan, already the vice-president, could succeed him as WFI president. Horrified, a small circle of dissent began growing around Vinesh, who Dhriti says was the most courageous of Singh's